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Smartphones are ubiquitous around the world now, especially due to falling data prices and the increased number of value for money devices. However, smartphone manufacturers are constantly coming out with new flagship devices with premium specs and features that entice users to purchase them over their value for money counterparts. Although flagship smartphones may have the most eye-catching specs and features, the prices have been exponentially rising year-over-year as well. iPhones that were priced around ₹70-80K a few years ago are now way past the ₹1 lakh mark, some even touching ₹1.5 lakhs. However, performance-wise, the leap is not as large, in the grand scheme of things, in comparison to the price hike.

In some areas such as cameras, the leap in performance is more tangible in most flagship smartphones, but the same kind of leap is happening in more value for money devices such as OnePlus and even Xiaomi. So, expensive doesn't always equate to better

performance and durability. And in a market with burgeoning prices and falling resale prices, it absolutely makes more financial sense to purchase more value for money devices. How can you go about identifying such devices? Let's delve into that.

WHAT IS A VALUE FOR MONEY SMARTPHONE?

Value is something that is inherently subjective. For someone earning ₹25,000 a month, a ₹15-20K smartphone would be considered value

for money, whereas a person earning much more, the sweet spot could be priced above 50K. However, what is common in both these instances is that a value for money gadget often offers similar specs and features for a lower price than the flagship or high-end products. An example is the Samsung Galaxy S20 FE that offers an AMOLED display at under 40K, however, the Realme 8 costing merely ₹15,000 also features an AMOLED display. In this case, the Realme device is nearly ₹25,000 cheaper but from the display perspective, offers a greater bang for your buck.

In fact, the specs difference between high-end and budget phones is slowly but surely getting narrower than ever before. Let's take last year's Samsung Galaxy S21 Ultra as an example. The device came with the Qualcomm Snapdragon 888 SoC in US and China and the Exynos 2100 SoC in other markets. The device also had a 108-megapixel primary camera and a large 5,000mAh battery.

Now, let's compare this to the Xiaomi 11T Pro that launched in January. You get the same Snapdragon 888 5nm processor as the S21 Ultra's US counterpart. In fact, Indian users get the Exynos 2100 SoC which is considered inferior in terms of thermal performance and graphics performance. You also get a 108MP primary lens with the same f/1.8 aperture and a superior 26mm lens width in comparison to the S21 Ultra's 24mm lens. You also get a 5,000mAh battery, and what's better



Samsung Galaxy S21 Ultra (left) vs Xiaomi 11T Pro (right)